



**COMSATS Institute of Information Technology
Wah**

Pillars of Islam (Sawm/Fasting)

Lecture No. 11

Sha'ban - 2nd year after migration to Madina

- Mandatory for Muslims and earlier people
- Time is reduced for Muslims
 - Jews → dawn to nightfall
 - Christians → 24 hours

Sawm (Arabic: صوم) is an Arabic word for fasting regulated by Islamic jurisprudence.

The observance of *sawm* during the Islamic holy month of Ramadan is one of the Five Pillars of Islam, but is not confined to that month.

Literal Meaning: abstinence

Literary Meaning: It means abstaining from things that break the fast, from dawn until sunset, having first made the intention to do so.

Types of *Sawm*:

Obligatory:

- The fast of Ramadan
- Fasting in expiation for killing someone by mistake
- Divorcing one's wife by *dhihaar*
- Or having intercourse during the day in Ramadan
- Making up days missed in Ramadan

Non Obligatory:

- 'Aashooraa'
- The Day of 'Arafah
- Ayyaam al-Beed
- Mondays and Thursdays
- Six days of Shawwaal\

Some Rulings concerning *Sawm*:

- Fasting is an obligation on every adult, sane, resident [i.e., not traveling] Muslim who is able to fast and has nothing to prevent him or her from doing so.

- It is not permitted to single out Friday for fasting or to fast on a Saturday unless it is an obligatory fast.
- It is not permitted to fast for an entire lifetime, or to fast for two days or more without a break.
- It is haram to fast on the two Eid days.
- Pregnant or breastfeeding woman is permitted not to fast like one who is ill.

Significance and Virtues of *Sawm*:

One of the greatest acts of worship is fasting, which Allah has made obligatory on His slaves.

He says: [2:183] يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا كُتِبَ عَلَيْكُمُ الصِّيَامُ كَمَا كُتِبَ عَلَى الَّذِينَ مِن قَبْلِكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ

“Observing al-siyaam (the fast) is prescribed for you as it was prescribed for those before you, that you may become al-muttaqoon (the pious).” [al-Baqarah 2:183]

- Multiplied Reward: Allah has chosen fasting for Himself, and He will reward it and multiply the reward without measure, as He says [in a Hadith e Qudsi]: *“Except for fasting which is only for My sake, and I will reward him for it.”*
- No equal: Fasting has no equal and the du‘aa (supplication) of the fasting person will not be refused.
- Intercession: Fasting will intercede for a person on the Day of Judgment and will say, *“O Lord, I prevented him from his food and physical desires during the day, so let me intercede for him.”*
- Smell of a fasting person: The smell that comes from the mouth of a fasting person is more beloved to Allah than the scent of musk.
- Protection from Hell fire: Fasting is a protection and a strong fortress that keeps a person safe from the Fire. *Whoever fasts one day for the sake of Allah, Allah will distance him from the Fire a distance of seventy years from the Fire.*
- Entering Paradise: Whoever fasts one day seeking the pleasure of Allah, he will enter Paradise. *“In Paradise there is a gate called al-Rayyaan through which those who fast will enter, and no one will enter through it except them; when they have entered it will be locked, and no-one else will enter through it”.*

The Benefits of Fasting

- Gaining Taqwaa: Allah mentioned in the verse: *“...that you may become al-muttaqoon (the pious).”* [al- Baqarah 2:183] The interpretation of this verse is that if a person refrains from Halal things hoping to gain the pleasure of Allah and out of fear of His punishment, it will be easier for him to refrain from doing Haram things.

- Compassion towards the poor: When the fasting person feels the pangs of hunger, he experiences how the poor feel, thus he feels compassion towards them and gives them something to ward off their hunger. Hearing about them is not the same as sharing their suffering, just as a rider does not understand the hardship of walking until he gets down and walks.
- Refrainment from sin: Fasting trains the person to avoid desires and to keep away from sin; it helps a person to overcome his own nature and to wean himself away from bad habits.
- Punctuality and Regularity: It also trains a person to get used to being organized and punctual, which will solve the problem that many people have of being disorganized, if only they realized.
- Unity: Fasting is also a demonstration of the unity of the Muslims, as the Ummah (Islamic nation) fasts and breaks its fast all at the same time.

The Etiquettes and Sunan of Fasting

- Suhur: Some aspects of fasting are obligatory (Fard) and others are recommended (sunnah). The Prophet said: *“Have suhoor, for in suhoor there is blessing (Barakah).”*
- Hastiness in Iftaar: One should not delay iftaar, because the Prophet said: *“The people remain upon goodness so long as they do not delay Iftaar.”*
- Supplication of braking fast: The Prophet, when he broke his fast, would say: *“The thirst has gone, the veins are flowing again, and the reward is confirmed, in shaa Allah.”*
- Keeping away from sin: The Prophet said: *“Whoever does not stop speaking falsehood and acting in accordance with it, Allaah has no need of him giving up his food and drink.”* (al-Bukhaari:1903).
- Wasting time: Among the things that can destroy one’s good deeds and cause bad deeds to be recorded is allowing oneself to be distracted by movies and sports matches, idle gatherings, hanging about in the streets with evil people and time-wasters, driving around for no purpose, and crowding the streets and sidewalks.
- To provoke: A person should not allow himself to be provoked, because the Prophet PBUH said: *“If someone fights him or insults him, he should say, ‘I am fasting, I am fasting.’”* One reason for this is to remind him, and the other reason is to remind the one who is provoking him.

Timings of Fasting:

Course: Islamic Studies
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- Why dawn to sunset is chosen?
- Why one month is selected?
 - Very few days would have no significance
 - Very long period will affect the health
- Why lunar calendar is chosen?
- Why Ramdhan is chosen?
 - Month of start of revelation is selected

Purpose of Fasting:

- Two instincts of man
 - Animalistic instinct
 - Angelistic instinct
- Animalistic instinct
 - Greed, dishonesty, hatred, love of resources, killings, theft etc
- Angelistic Instinct
 - Helping people, providing food, shelter, medicine
- Initially man is a raw material
- He can develop any instinct by following a path
- Fasting and other teachings are for developing Angelistic instinct
- 'no to eat' is a special Angel's instinct